What Would Make You Look Again? Changes in Dad's Health, Finances, Household and Daily Needs Worth Writing Down

Fifteen everyday changes to notice and put a date on, with no interpreting.

Dad's situation is steady today. Over a few years a policy renews, an account moves, a routine changes, and the page you wrote about how care might be paid for describes an earlier year. This guide names fifteen everyday changes worth noticing and, for each, what to write down.

Notice and record. Don't interpret. What a change means for Dad's plan is a question for a professional, and a dated note is what makes that conversation useful. The four kinds of change (health, finances, marital status and care needs) are the ones the roadmap names for looking at the plan again. The details about records, policies and accounts follow the public sources listed below; the wording about what to write down is ours.

Health

1 A change in Dad's health

NOTICE Something a doctor told him, a new routine with his medicines, a procedure, a few weeks when he wasn't himself.

WRITE DOWN What changed and when, the way Dad describes it. What it means medically is for his doctor to say.

2 His health coverage

NOTICE A new insurance card in his wallet, a letter from his health plan about changes, a plan he has switched to or dropped.

WRITE DOWN The plan's name as printed on the card, the date of the change, and where the letter is kept.

Money coming in and going out

3 What comes in [1]

NOTICE A pension or Social Security deposit that changed, interest or dividends that started or stopped, part-time work that ended.

WRITE DOWN Which source, what changed and when, copied from the statement and not from memory.

4 The regular bills

NOTICE A new monthly bill, an old one that has grown, a premium notice with a different amount on it.

WRITE DOWN Which bill, the old amount and the new one, and the month it changed.

5 A large amount in or out [2]

NOTICE A sale, an inheritance, a big purchase or repair, a loan to a relative, a gift made or received.

WRITE DOWN The date, the amount, the reason and the names of the people or companies involved, with where the paperwork is. No opinion attached.

6 Who pays the bills, and how [2]

NOTICE Whether Dad still writes the checks himself, whether someone has started lending a hand, which account the bills are paid from.

WRITE DOWN Who does what, from which account, and since when.

Policies, accounts and property

7 Mail about an insurance policy [3]

NOTICE A renewal, a change in the premium, a notice about a long-term care or life insurance policy, a policy that ended.

WRITE DOWN The company, the policy as it is named on the letter, the date, and where the letter is. Questions about what the policy covers go to the company.

8 An annuity or retirement account statement [4]

NOTICE A statement that looks different from last year's, payments that began, a letter about a change in the contract or the account.

WRITE DOWN The company, the date, and what the letter says changed, in its own words. An annuity's terms vary by product, so the contract is the thing to keep.

9 Accounts opened, closed, moved or renamed [2]

NOTICE A new bank, an account that was closed or combined, a second name added to one or taken off.

WRITE DOWN Which account, whose names are on it, and when it changed. Change nothing yourself; a change someone has in mind goes on the question list.

10 The house [5]

NOTICE A new tax bill, a refinance or a home equity loan, an appraisal, a mortgage paid off, talk of selling.

WRITE DOWN What happened and when, and where the tax bill, the appraisal and the mortgage papers are kept.

The household

11 A change in marital status [5]

NOTICE A wedding, a separation, a divorce, or the loss of a husband or wife, in Dad's own life.

WRITE DOWN The event and the date. Nothing more is needed on the page.

12 A move, or who lives in the house [3]

NOTICE A new address, plans to move nearer family, a relative who has moved in or out.

WRITE DOWN From where, to where, who, and when, including a move across a state line.

Daily needs

13 What Dad has handed over

NOTICE Driving after dark, the yard, the taxes, the grocery run: things he used to do himself and now leaves to someone else.

WRITE DOWN What, who does it now, and since when. Describe it. Don't decide what it means.

14 Paid help starting [6]

NOTICE Someone coming in to clean, drive, cook or lend a hand for a few hours.

WRITE DOWN Who comes, what they do, how often, what they charge, and how they are paid.

Conversations

15 Suggestions and offers [7]

NOTICE “Put the house in the kids' names.” An invitation to a retirement seminar. A call about a product, or a new adviser's business card.

WRITE DOWN Who suggested or offered what, and when, with the name and title on the card. Write it as a question for a professional. Nothing gets done from a note.

When a note isn't enough

A note is for something that has already happened. When someone is about to give away, move or retitle something of Dad's, or to buy, change or cancel a policy or a financial product, that is a question for a professional first, and the note goes with it: your Medicaid planner for how it fits the plan to pay for care, an elder law attorney for a legal question, a licensed insurance or financial professional for a product. A change in Dad's health goes to his doctor. This guide sets no threshold: if you can't tell whether a change matters, write it down and ask.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what any of these changes means for Medicaid, for a policy or for Dad's plan, and it isn't legal, financial or tax advice. A professional who knows his state does that, and does it better with your dated notes in front of them.

Ready for the next step?

You know which changes to notice and put a date on. The planning interview asks about your family's situation as it is today and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Medicaid Eligibility

2. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Managing Someone Else's Money: Help for agents under a power of attorney
3. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), How can I pay for nursing home care?
4. National Council on Aging, What Is an Annuity? Types, Costs, Benefits, and Risks
5. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Applying for Medicaid
6. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Costs of Care
7. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Know your financial adviser

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